PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 5

Performing

Playing for others is a skill you can practise, like scales. Nerves are normal: they mean you care. A routine before you start and a plan for slips make them much smaller.

THE SECRET

Breathe, feel a bar of the beat, then begin. After a slip, catch the next beat.



Four steps to the first note

WHEN	WHAT YOU DO
Before	warm up your hands; practise starting, not only the whole piece; play it to a friend or family first
At the piano	adjust the bench; feet flat; breathe out; feel one bar of the beat in your head
If you slip	keep the beat going; catch the next beat or the next phrase; never go back
After	hands in your lap for a moment, stand, bow, smile

THE RULE

The listener follows the beat and the mood. Keep both going and a slip is forgotten in a second.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Every day this week, play your piece once from the start without stopping, whatever happens, as if someone were listening.

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Playing from memory

Learn it in sections and know where each starts. Memory works best when it is **four kinds at once**: the sound, the feel in your fingers, the look of the page, and knowing the chords and the form.

HOW TO

Practise performing

1. **Choose three starting places** in your piece and practise starting from each.
2. **Play it through once a day** without stopping, whatever happens.
3. **Play to someone**: a friend, family, a phone camera.

PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

How do you start?

You sit down.
Your heart is racing. ?

1. **The bench:** right height, right distance?
2. **Your breath:** in, then out slowly.
3. **The beat:** what do you hear first?

Adjust, breathe out, and **feel one bar** of the speed in your head. Then the first note.

EXAMPLE 2

You slip in bar 5: what now?

Bar 5: a wrong note, and your hand freezes ?

1. **Do you stop** and start again?
2. **Where is the beat** now?
3. **Where can you rejoin?**

Keep counting and come back in on the **next beat**, or at the start of the next phrase. Never go back.

GAME

Help or not?

1 going back

2 breathe first

3 keep the beat

4 rush to finish

Which help a performance?

Answer: 2 and 3 help; 1 and 4 do not.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

breathe · beat · play · bow

A one-minute concert.

Choose eight bars. Walk to the piano, sit, breathe, feel a bar, play, bow. Do it for someone today.

THINK OF IT The audience wants you to do well: they are on your side from the first note.

TRAP

- × Starting before you are ready: breathe and feel the beat first.
- × Apologising with your face after a slip: keep going and nobody minds.

SEE ALSO
Practising well p. 165 · Expression p. 76

PRACTISE IT
Online: Practice log